

What is Social Justice?

In the world of philanthropy, we often hear the phrase **social justice**. But what *exactly* does it mean? While you probably have a general idea, would you be able to define it in a short soundbite if you were put on the spot?

Several organizations and institutions provide their own definitions. Here are a few:

“Social justice may be broadly understood as the fair and compassionate distribution of the fruits of economic growth.”

[United Nations](#)

“Social justice is the view that everyone deserves equal economic, political and social rights and opportunities. Social workers aim to open the doors of access and opportunity for everyone, particularly those in greatest need.”

[National Association of Social Workers](#)

Understanding Social Justice

The concept of social justice first arose in the 19th century during the Industrial Revolution as attempts were made to promote more egalitarian societies and reduce the exploitation of certain marginalized groups due to the vast disparity between the rich and poor at the time. Social justice initially focused on issues such as the distribution of capital, property, and wealth due to the extreme levels of inequality and economic distress prevalent at the time, resulting from the European social class structure.

Today, social justice has shifted towards a stronger emphasis on human rights and improving the lives of disadvantaged and marginalized groups that have historically faced discrimination in society. Many of these groups have been discriminated against on the basis of factors such as sex, age, wealth, ethnicity, heritage, social status, religion, and others. Social justice often leads to efforts to redistribute wealth to some of the underprivileged groups through providing income, jobs, and education support and opportunities.

Main Principles of Social Justice

While there is no single definition of social justice, most approaches share the broad goals of inclusion and fairness. In order to achieve those goals, they establish a set of ethical principles for a just society.

These principles may include:

1. Access to Resources

Access to resources is an important principle of social justice and refers to the extent to which different socioeconomic groups receive equal access to give everyone an equal start in life. Many societies offer a multitude of resources and services for their citizens, such as healthcare, food, shelter, education, and recreational opportunities. However, unequal access to such services often exists.

For example, individuals from wealthy households among the upper and upper-middle classes are often better able to afford to attend good schools and access post-secondary education, which leads to a greater chance of obtaining jobs with higher income in the future. In contrast, those from the lower classes face fewer opportunities. It, in turn, limits access to education for future generations and continues the cycle of facing disadvantages.

Equity

Equity is the principle that people should have the same opportunities to succeed, despite any past injustices or systemic discrimination. This may mean that resources are distributed in a way that addresses the specific needs of underprivileged communities or people.

Equity refers to how individuals are given tools specific to their needs and socioeconomic status in order to move towards similar outcomes. It contrasts with equality, where everyone is offered the same tools to move towards the same outcome.

Diversity

Understanding diversity and appreciating the value of cultural differences are especially important because policymakers are often better able to construct policies that take into consideration differences that exist among different societal groups. It is important to recognize that some groups face more barriers in society, and by considering the inequities, policymakers and civil servants will be in a stronger position to expand opportunities for marginalized or disadvantaged groups.

Discrimination in employment on the basis of factors such as race, gender, ethnicity, sex, age, and other characteristics are constant issues in society, and enforcing policies to countermand discriminatory practices are one way in which diversity is taken into consideration.

Participation

Participation refers to how everyone in society is given a voice and opportunity to verbalize their opinions and concerns and have a role in any decision-making that affects their livelihood and standard of living. Social injustice occurs when a small group of individuals makes decisions for a large group, while some people are unable to voice their opinions.

Human Rights

Human rights are one of the most important principles of social justice and form a foundational part of the concept. Human rights and social justice are certainly interrelated, and it is impossible for one to exist without the other.

Human rights are fundamental to societies that respect the civil, economic, political, cultural, and legal rights of individuals and governments, organizations, and individuals must be held responsible if they fail to ensure the upholding of these rights

Social Justice Issues

Social justice encompasses a wide range of issues and advocates for the fair treatment of all people, regardless of race, gender, ability or socioeconomic status.

Some of the most pressing social justice issues include:

- **Economic Inequality:** The gap between the rich and the poor is growing wider in many countries. This is a major social justice issue, leading to a lack of opportunity for the poor and marginalized.
- **Racial Injustice:** People of color are disproportionately affected by poverty, crime and violence and face discrimination in employment, housing and education.
- **Gender Injustice:** Women and girls have historically been denied the same rights and opportunities as men and face discrimination in the workplace, in education and in politics.
- **Disability Injustice:** People with disabilities are often denied the same rights and opportunities as people without disabilities and face discrimination at work and in their communities.
- **Environmental Injustice:** People of color and low-income communities are often disproportionately affected by environmental pollution and the impacts of climate change.

Examples of Social Justice Issues

- **The Civil Rights Movement:** This movement fought for the rights of Black Americans, including the right to vote, the right to equal education and the right to equal employment opportunities.
- **The Women's Suffrage Movement:** This movement fought for the right of women to vote.
- **The Disability Rights Movement:** This movement fought for the rights of people with disabilities, including the right to education, the right to employment and the right to live independently.
- **The Environmental Justice Movement:** This movement fights for the fair treatment of all people concerning environmental hazards and the protection of the environment.